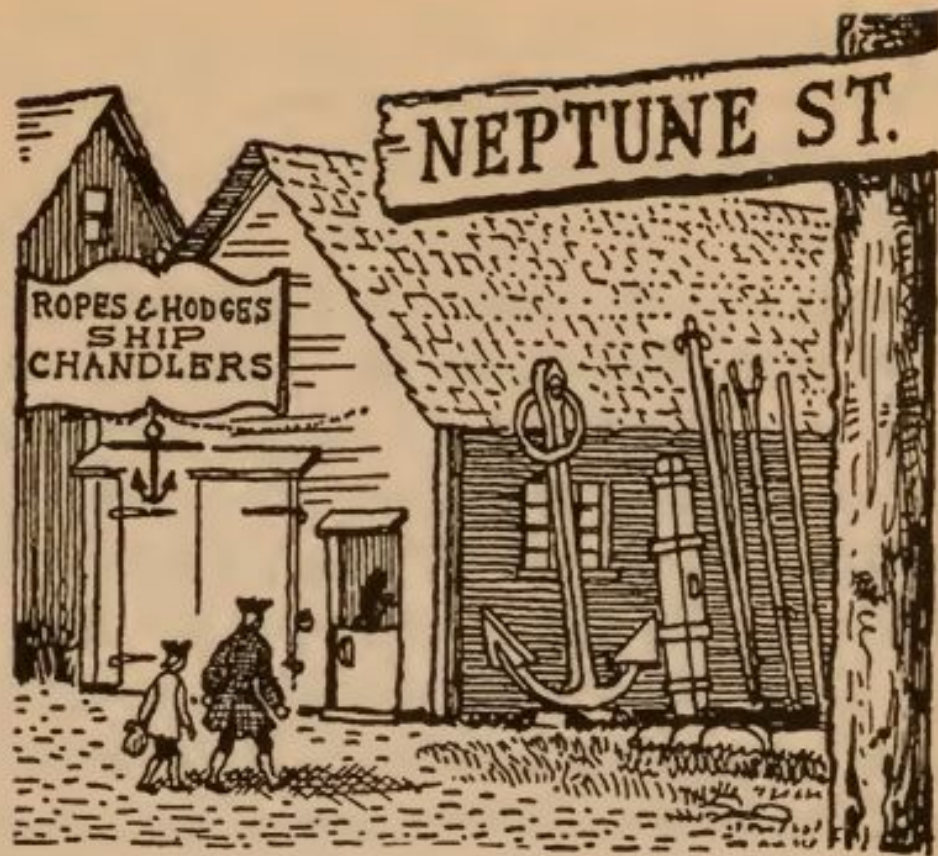


Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 5



CHAPTER 5



A VOICE IN THE NIGHT

It was an early winter. A nor'easter howled in from the Atlantic, bringing rain that changed to sleet and then to snow. Nat hugged his thin coat about him and scurried back from an errand. The sleet lashed his face and brought tears to his eyes, so that he could not see where he was going. He ran into a man, stumbled and lost his balance. He went down in the mud and slush. "Excuse me," he said. He looked up and recognized the roly-poly man. He gasped, "Excuse me, sir!"

It was the new pastor of East Church — Dr. Bentley. Everyone said Dr. Bentley was about the brightest man who had ever come to Salem. They said he knew twenty languages!

Dr. Bentley helped Nat to his feet, took out a handkerchief, and wiped at the mud on Nat's clothes. "No, no. Excuse me. You're the one who tumbled." He must have noticed how thin Nat's coat was. He said, "This cold spell took a man by surprise, didn't it? No time to get his winter coat out of the garret."

Nat's answer was always ready. "I don't get cold; only sissies need winter coats." Then he saw the heavy coat that bundled Dr. Bentley. "I — I — mean — when you're young, you know. Of course when a man gets old, I guess he needs a heavy coat. I — I — mean —"

Dr. Bentley chuckled. "That's right. Old fellows of twenty-five — like me — have to watch their health." He walked along toward the cooperage with Nat. "You're Nathaniel Bowditch, aren't you? I've heard Master Watson talk about you. You're not in school today?"

"I've quit school to help my father."

Dr. Bentley stared at him. "What? But that's — that's — " He stopped. After a while he said, "I'll leave you here, Nat. Good-by."

When Nat got home that evening, Lizza was big-eyed. When she had a chance, she whispered, "Dr. Bentley came to see Mother! He told her you ought to be getting ready for Harvard right now! Isn't that wonderful? When a man as bright as Dr. Bentley says you're bright, too?"

"What did Mother say?"

"She thanked him! And she smiled and smiled. After he had gone, she didn't smile, though. She walked back and forth. And Granny said 'Stop stewing about that boy and take care of yourself.' "

Something colder than a nor'easter settled in Nat's chest. "Granny's worried about Mother."

Lizza nodded slowly. "I know. But Mother always laughs and says 'I'm all right.' She said that today. She said, 'I'll live to see Nat a Harvard man.' "

Not quite three months later, just before Christmas, Mother died.

The night after the funeral, Father sat at the table with his head in his hands. "I'll do better, Mother," he said. "I swear I will."

Granny's eyes were sad. "I hope so, son. But you'd better claw off that lee shore. You've lost your anchor to windward."

Mary put her arm around Granny. "Why don't you go to bed, dear?"

Granny sighed. "I think I will. Seems like I've lost my tuck."

Not quite two years later, when Nat was twelve, Granny died.

Again Father sat by the table with his head in his hands. Again he said, "I'll do better, Mary. I swear I will."

Mary didn't answer. She just looked at Father. Her eyes were sad as Granny's used to be.

Nat knew what she was thinking. "You've lost your last anchor to windward."

Two months later, something awakened Nat in the night. He raised up on one scrawny elbow and stared into the dark. What was it? He listened. There were only the sounds he had known all these years in Salem — the creaking of the old wooden house, buffeted by Atlantic winds. No other sounds. But something had awakened him. He shivered, and started to huddle down under the

blanket again. Then he heard his father's voice. Father must be talking to Mary. Since Mother and Granny were gone, they all turned to Mary.

At first Father's voice was only a rumble. Then Nat heard the scrape of a chair and the thud of a log being pitched on the fire.

For a moment Father's voice was louder. "I think it's the thing for Nat. He's not much good in the cooperage; he's better with his head than his hands. He won't be bringing in any money, but there will be one less mouth to feed. Master Watson always said he was bright. And I talked to Michael Walsh. He said . . . "

The chair scraped again. Father's voice died to a rumble. Nat could no longer hear what he was saying. But he had heard enough to know what they were talking about. Michael Walsh was a teacher!

Nat sat up again. The covers fell away, but he did not notice the cold. He was going to go back to school! He must be going away somewhere to school. Father had said, "One less mouth to feed."

Surprised, Nat found tears on his face and wiped them with the back of his hand. "That's funny," he said. "I don't cry. Boys don't blubber."

Silly to cry when he was happy enough to burst. He was going back to school! Where — he didn't know — but somewhere. And after he had learned all he could in that school, he'd go to Harvard. How, he didn't know. He just knew that he would. Latin — he'd have to learn Latin to go to Harvard. Maybe that was why he was going away somewhere to school. So he could learn Latin to get ready for Harvard.

When he got to Harvard, Nat told himself, he'd work hard — harder than he had ever worked in his life. When he finished Harvard, his father could come to his graduation. Mary, too. And Lizza. Maybe the whole family!

Father would say, "Nat, I did the right thing when I took you out of the cooperage and put you back to book learning. As a cooper, you're a good Latin scholar."

And they'd laugh together. Nat wished he could jump out of bed now and go talk to his father about it — tell him what he had heard. But that wouldn't be fair. This was Father's surprise. He must have the fun of telling it. Tomorrow, at breakfast, that was when Father would tell him. Tell him he was going back to school!

Smiling, Nat lay down again. For a long time he lay there, too full of plans to go to sleep.

The next morning when he awakened, it was late. Only Father and Mary were at the table. As Nat ate his breakfast, he watched his Father's face for some sign of a twinkle to show he was thinking about the surprise. But Father frowned over a paper he was studying and never looked up. Nat glanced toward Mary, to see if she showed a twinkle. But Mary looked pale, as though she hadn't slept very well.

At last Father pushed back his chair and cleared his throat. "Er — Nat . . . "

It was coming now! "Yes, Father?"

"I've been thinking a lot about you, Nat. You know, I believe you'll do better with your head than with your hands."

"I think so, too." Nat couldn't keep from grinning.

Father said, "I've been talking to Jonathan Hodges about you. You know — of Ropes and Hodges."

Nat said, "I know who he is." Mr. Hodges must be the one that talked Father into sending Nat back to school. Father would pay attention to what Mr. Hodges said. Everyone talked about how well Ropes and Hodges were doing. Just twenty-one or so, both of them, and they had the biggest ship chandlery in Salem. Nat had been in the chandlery — a long wooden building on Neptune Street, near Union Wharf. The chandlery was crammed with everything for ships — everything from barrels of salt beef to cables and marline-spikes. Yes, Father would pay attention to what Mr. Hodges said.

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Father frowned and seemed to be hunting for words. "Er — ah — Jonathan Hodges thinks you show a good bit of promise, Nat. He thinks a couple of months — maybe three — under Michael Walsh will give you just what you need."

Two months under Michael Walsh — or three. Nat tried to figure it out. Mr. Walsh was right here in town. Father had said there would be "one less mouth to feed."

Father said, "Mr. Hodges knows you're quick at figures. He says Mr. Walsh can teach you enough book-keeping in two or three months. Then Ropes and Hodges will sign your papers." He looked at the paper he had been studying and then handed it to Nat. Nat began to read:

INDENTURE

This indenture witnesseth that
NATHANIEL BOWDITCH

hath put himself, and, by these Presents, doth
voluntarily and of his own free will and accord, and
with the consent of

HABAKKUK BOWDITCH

put and bind himself apprentice to

ROPES AND HODGES

to learn the Art, Trade or Mystery of

SHIP CHANDLERY

for and during a term of NINE YEARS.

Nat picked up the paper and held it in front of his face. *Nine years!* Until he was twenty-one! For nine years he would belong to the Ship Chandlery of Ropes and Hodges. For nine years! The paper blurred in front of his eyes. He caught a sentence here and there: "During all which said term the said apprentice NATHANIEL BOWDITCH shall faithfully serve . . . He shall not absent himself by Day or Night from the same Ropes and Hodges Service without leave . . . "

He'd live there, too. That was what Father had meant. "No money," he had said, "just one less mouth to feed." *He'd live there.* In two months — or three — just as soon as he knew enough bookkeeping — he'd leave home and go to live with Mr. Ropes or Mr. Hodges. For nine years *he would not leave by Day or Night without permission.*

Father said, "Well, Nat, what do you think?"

Nat stole a glance from behind the paper toward Mary. Poor Mary, she looked so worried. Hab had said boys took care of girls and women. Kept them from worrying.

Nat managed to grin. "I think I'll do better with bookkeeping than barrel staves, all right. There's just one part of this that bothers me."

"Yes, Nat?"

“It says here I must not contract matrimony. After all, when a man is twelve . . . ”

Mary said, “Oh, Nat, you simpleton!” Her laugh was shaky, but she did laugh.

Nat got up quickly. “I think I’ll hurry right over to Mr. Walsh’s.”

He whistled while he found his slate and pencil. He whistled until he was out of the house and up the street. Then the whistle died.

All the way to Mr. Walsh’s house Nat’s feet seemed to beat out the words: Nine years . . . nine years . . . nine years . . .

Two or three months to study bookkeeping. Then no more school — ever.

Indentured: Nathaniel Bowditch.